

BENEDICTINE 64, OLMSTED FALLS 57

Falls stood tall

Intangibles led Bulldogs to top last year's run

Steve Byrne
The Chronicle-Telegram

TOLEDO — They weren't as tall as last year's Bulldogs.

The team didn't have the outside shooters the 1996 club had either.

No way this year's Olmsted Falls boys basketball team could make it as far as last season's crew, which lost in the regional semifinals.

But it did. One game farther, in fact.

"If you had told me this year's team would win 23 games and lose to Benedictine in the regional final," Coach Pat Donahue said, "I would have bet my house (against it happening), and now you would be living in my house instead of yours."

The Bulldogs can look back at that sometime, but the evening of March 15 wasn't the time.

"What hurts so bad is you work your whole life for this and you see it slip away in three minutes," said John Storey, a senior co-captain and starting point guard for Falls.

"We're best friends," Storey added while motioning to all-state forward Tim Schaefer, the other co-captain. "I now realize I'll probably never play ball with him again."

At least not organized basketball. The Bulldogs let a six-point lead evaporate as Benedictine scored 18 points in the last 3:18 to claim a 64-57 victory in the championship game of the Division II regional tournament.

But a 23-2 record (best in school history) isn't too shabby, particularly when two long-



TOM MAHL / CHRONICLE

HAVING THE DRIVE: Senior guard John Storey, going to the basket Saturday against Benedictine, and senior forward Tim Schaefer (00) were two reasons Olmsted Falls turned in its best season in school history.

range gunners from last season — Tim Matus and Matt Tabar — graduated.

So how did Olmsted Falls do it?

"We were tougher — mentally tougher," Storey said. "This is the hardest working group I've ever seen. That's not taking anything away from any other team, but this year's team had the intangibles a team needs in a regional."

"It's not about shooting or any of that. You saw what happened. We were four minutes from beating those guys."

It didn't happen. But now the

1997 Olmsted Falls team has established a standard that succeeding teams can try to surpass.

And if that team, if there is such a team, comes along, it will probably have to have wholesale amounts of talent. If Donahue is to be believed, it likely will not exceed the level of class exhibited by a club that was supposed to be Schaefer and 11 other guys in the same color uniform.

"Usually you have one or maybe two kids who are that special," the coach said. "This is the first time I've seen a whole team of players you'd like to bring home and have live with you."

FALLS

From D1

"Our pressure defense finally caught up with them. They just wore down. At the end they were grasping for breath."

Todd Back was the key player in the comeback as he connected on two 3-pointers and added a putback basket after a key rebound in a span of just over one minute. In that period the Bengals came from four points down, 52-48, to a five-point lead, 60-55, with 1:16 left.

Back was also a key player (fullback and linebacker) in Benedictine's 28-7 playoff football victory over Falls.

The Bengals went on to win the state football championship in Division III.

"This is a magical season for us," Back said. "To think we have a chance to win both a football and basketball championship in one school year really feels great."

Olmsted Falls was sailing along behind the super play of

6-foot-8 all-state candidate Tim Schaefer. He had 14 points and seven rebounds by halftime as the Bulldogs took a three-point lead, 29-26. It mounted to 10 points late in the third quarter.

But Schaefer got only three points in the fourth period and four rebounds the last half.

More importantly, although a beefy 6-8, Schaefer did not get a single offensive rebound the entire game, meaning no putbacks or tip-ins. That's because Benedictine had some big people of its own in 6-7 Albert Wilson and 6-6 Jermaine Crosby, who made Schaefer work for every point he got.

"I don't think Wilson and Crosby played up to their potential early in the game," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "But in the second half they did. The whole team did a great job with their pressure defense at the end and we didn't execute. Rebounding, we just flat-out got boxed out."

"But let me say this, I have so much pride in these kids. This is the greatest group of kids, as a whole, I've ever been connected with."

Olmsted Falls shot a sizzling 57 percent (20 of 35) for the game, but its 19 turnovers hurt, especially in some key situations in the fatal fourth quarter. Benedictine had only 11 turnovers.

The Bengals shot 44 percent from the field and won the rebound battle, 33-30.

Schaefer led Falls with 23 points and 11 rebounds. Top rebounders for the Bengals were Crosby and Wilson with seven each.

Benedictine will play in its first state tournament in Columbus on Thursday at 6 p.m.

Benedictine (64)										
Player	FGA	FG	FTA	FT	F	TP	Reb	Ass	Stk	Pts
Patton Brown	15	10	7	5	2	25	16	1	0	16
Todd Back	14	6	2	1	4	11	1	0	0	13
Albert Wilson	9	5	2	1	4	11	1	0	0	11
Chris Leanza	7	2	0	0	2	5	1	0	0	5
Bill Marsch	2	1	3	2	1	4	1	0	0	4
Jermaine Crosby	4	1	4	1	3	3	1	0	0	3
Michael Woods	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0
Casey Behn	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0
Anthony Holly	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0
Totals	57	25	18	9	19	64	33	2	0	64

Olmsted Falls (57)										
Player	FGA	FG	FTA	FT	F	TP	Reb	Ass	Stk	Pts
Tim Schaefer	13	9	5	3	2	23	11	1	0	23
Sean Rodigan	3	3	6	5	5	11	1	0	0	9
John Storey	6	4	2	1	5	9	1	0	0	9
Dan Perante	3	2	6	4	3	9	1	0	0	6
Marvin Williams	3	1	2	1	2	3	1	0	0	3
Jim Kaemba	2	1	0	0	0	2	1	0	0	2
Josh Schneider	2	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Keth Knapp	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Totals	35	20	21	14	18	57	18	2	0	57

Three-pointers: Benedictine — Back 4, Leanza, Olmsted Falls — Schaefer 2, Perante										
SCORE BY QUARTERS										
Benedictine	13	13	11	27	64					
Olmsted Falls	10	13	16	12	57					

Crunch scores league-record 52 points

COLUMBUS — The Crunch shattered a National Professional Soccer League record for most points scored in a game in its 52-18 win over the Columbus Invaders Saturday.

The previous record of 38 was held by the old Dayton Dynamo,

now the Cincinnati Silverbacks, and scored against Detroit in November, 1994.

The win was the Crunch's 16th in its last 18 games.

Crunch forward Hector Marinero recorded a triple soccer cycle — the first in league history. He

knocked in 12 goals and handed out three assists for 26 points — an NPSL record for most points scored in a game.

The previous record was 19 held by Marinero's teammate Zoran Karic against Columbus on Jan. 25.

BOWLING SCORES

RAINBOW COUPLES: Bulldogs-Goez 56-22, Strawderman-Abram 50-27, Logsdon-Ayala 46-31, Mandell-Hawley 45-32, Cur Gary 44-33, Leanza-Rose 39-38, Peck-King 38-39, Armas-Grimmer 35-42, Monroe's 32-45, Grandias & Grandpas 31-46, Sherbert-Mahone 25-52, Hendon-Brooks 22-65.

BOO BOO series: Jeff Schaefer 673, Larry Goez 681, Ed Mandell 656, Pam Goez 614, Clare Mandell 581, Bullocks-Goez 2300.

B.C. FIVE NITE "BOO": Elyria Bowling Ctr. 48-29, Stoney's Rainbow Lanes 47-30, Siman Chrysler 39-38, Campbell's Buffet 39-38, Ralph's Place 35-39, Schnur's Plaza 34-43, Looer's Barbors 32-45, S.W.A. 31-46.

BOO series: John Gregory 638, Elyria Bowling Ctr. 2970.

ELYRIA EAGLES 6431: Pioneer 62-36, Col. H. Roberts 54-34, P. Sunagel Investments 54-34, Stoney's 62-36, AAA Appliances 49-39, Erie Shore Mortgage 46-42, Haverstick Realty 42-48, Bad Boys 40-48, Barnwood Golf 39-50, Girls Only 35-53, LeGrand Bowling 32-56, R & B Drywall 24-64.

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St. Edward coasts to win in regional championship

Associated Press

BOYS BASKETBALL

Division II

Akron Buchtel..... 64
Youngstown Mooney.... 60

TOLEDO — Steve Logan scored 25 points as Lakewood St. Edward defeated Parma Valley Forge 63-38 Saturday in a Division I regional championship game.

St. Edward (24-1) increased a 16-10 lead after the first quarter to 26-13 by halftime.

Valley Forge (19-6), which was making its fifth regional appearance in 10 seasons, got within 37-30 with 7:22 left in the game before St. Edward broke away.

Gino Bartolone added 15 points for the Eagles, while Sam Clancy had 12 points and 11 rebounds. Ryan Patton and Kevin Collins led the Patriots with 12 and 11 points, respectively.

Cleveland Heights..... 73
Akron Firestone..... 64

CANTON — Jamaal Harris had 27 points and 10 rebounds to lead Cleveland Heights (22-3) to its fourth trip to the state semifinals in the last five years.

Heights led throughout most of game, but it was a 19-0 run that gave the Tigers a 65-48 lead with 4:57 left in the game.

Theo Dixon had 18 points for the Tigers while Tory Reed added 14 points and 12 rebounds.

Firestone (18-7) was led by Derek Williams with 16 points. James Johnson had 14, Julian Levy added 11 and Justin Levy scored 10.

Springfield North..... 55
Cincinnati Aiken..... 52

DAYTON — Eric Thomas scored 15 points and Springfield North rallied to defeat Cincinnati Aiken for the regional title.

North (20-6) trailed Aiken 44-38 after three quarters. Vaughn Stephens hit two 3-pointers, including one with 2:07 left that gave North a 54-51 lead.

Aiken (21-4) had outscored North 20-10 in the third quarter.

Stephens and Chris Strodes each added 12 points for North.

Aiken was led by Janerio Spurlock with 16 points. Lonnie Berry and Paul McMillan each had 10.

Division III

Franz each added 10 points for the Rams.

For the Spartans, Brandon McIntosh scored 22 and Eugene Land added 18.

Division III

Cleveland VA-SJ..... 58
Youngstown Liberty..... 57

CANTON — Dale Thomas blocked a shot at the buzzer to preserve Cleveland Villa Angela-St. Joseph's victory over Youngstown Liberty in the regional final.

Thomas led VASJ (18-6) with 14 points and eight rebounds.

The Vikings led 57-48 with four minutes left, but scored only one more point the rest of the way.

Liberty (21-4) clawed its way back into the game. A basket and free throw by Damion Thomas cut the lead to one point with 1:03 to play. Neither team scored after that.

Ray Austin led Liberty with 16 points. Vernon Mills scored 12 and Damion Thomas had 11.

Patrick Henry 45
Ontario 43

BOWLING GREEN — Kris Gerken hit a 12-footer in the lane with 6.5 seconds left to give Patrick Henry the regional championship.

Patrick Henry (21-4) had trailed 41-33 with 5:34 left. Bryan Hiber and Jim Amspoker each hit a 3-pointer to get Patrick Henry back in the game.

Amspoker finished with 13 points while Gerken and Tony Hiser each had 12.

Ontario (23-2), which ousted Clearview in the semifinals, was led by Matt Smith with 12 points and Tony Dorsey with 10.

Belpre 66
Shenandoah..... 41

ATHENS — Kyle Bradford scored 14 points, including eight in the first quarter, as Belpre captured the regional title.

Belpre (14-12) opened a 19-8 lead at the end of the first quarter and built it from there. Shenandoah (22-3) got within 12 points (44-32) with two minutes left in the third quarter but no closer.

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